Before Women had Wings

By Connie May Fowler

BIRD: **(Pg 1-3)** Back in 1965, on a day so hot that God Almighty should have been writhing with sick-to-the-stomach guilt over driving His children out of the cool green of Eden, my daddy walked into our general store, held a revolver to his head, told my mama, Glory, that he couldn't take any more and that because of her harsh ways and his many sins he was going to blow his brains out.

INTRODUCTION

(Sing)
Some bright morning when this life is over
I'll fly away
To that home on God's celestial shore
I'll fly away

I'll fly away oh glory
I'll fly away
When I die hallelujah by and by
I'll fly away

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BIRD: I was six years old, and I prayed that my guardian angel, who so far in my life had proven to be an elusive helper, would materialize. Prayerful words welled up inside me, whirled through my head: Please angel, whisk me away. Take me to your house in the clouds, just for a little while, just for today.

BILLIE: *(Crying, voice loud and trembly)* Glory, I mean it. I'm sick and tired of trying to make it in this godforsaken world. You and the girls will be happier with me gone.

BIRD: Daddy's voice was loud, trembly. He was crying. I shut my eyes, and on the backs of my eyelids I saw Mama get up from behind the desk and put her arms around Daddy and coo, "Everything is going to be fine. Yes, baby, I love you. Your daughters love you." If I'd been her, I would have done that.

But my daydream did not come true. When I looked again, Mama was still sitting. When she spoke, her words pounded into me: "Jesus, Billy, you're behaving like a fool."

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Daddy raised the revolver to his temple, and for a split second the gun seemed alive, a blackbird flapping.

BILLIE: I swear to sweet Jesus, you're gonna be sorry, Glory.

BIRD: Then he slipped the weapon into the waistband of his pants and stormed out the front screen door.

GLORY: **(Pg 5)** Quit that foolish crying, Bird.

BIRD: I cried because my mama had told me not to. I cried because I didn't know what else to do.

(Pg 12) My true name is Avocet. Avocet Abigail Jackson. But because Mama couldn't find anyone who thought Avocet was a fine name for a child, she called me Bird. Which is okay by me. She named both her children after birds, her logic being that if were named for something with wings, then maybe then maybe we'd be able to fly above the shit in our lives.

(Pg 23) And so it went. And every night my parents fought:

BILLIE: **(Pg 22)** Listen here, I'm doing the best I can, woman. You know that. But I'm sick and tired of trying to please you. Nothing I do is good enough for you – Nothing!

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GLORY: Trying like hell! You son-of-a-bitch, when was the last time you tried anything that turned out right! You're no good, Billy Jackson, you're no damn good! **(Pg 54)** When was the last time you acted like a father to your girls instead of like a useless drunk?

BIRD: **(Pg 26)** Some nights I would put my pillow over my head, trying to block out the sound of their arguing. And I would pray to Jesus. I would say, "Dear sweet Jesus, give me angel wings so I can fly away from here." **(Pg 50)** Then I'd wonder if guardian angels really existed.

(Pg 54) Daddy inhaled, swung his arm as if it were a bat. Then his breath crashed across his lips as he backhanded Mama smack in the mouth. A thread of bright red blood trickled down her chin. **(Pg 67)** [Again and again] I saw everything so clearly and wished I hadn't. Her face was pummeled into ground beef. Her nose was no longer in the middle of her face. Her black-and-blue eyes were swollen shut. Mama might be dead. Summer crashed to pieces all around my feet.

PHOEBE: *(whispering)* She'll be okay."

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BIRD: **(Pg 50)** [Now] Phoebe, [my sister], and I suffered beatings as frequently as some children were showered with hugs.

GLORY: We're trying to make decent humans out of you.

BIRD: Mama would explain. And I'd wonder if there were children in the world who, at that very moment, were being doted on by fat grandmamas. Or little girls whose hair was being brushed out of their eyes as their mamas whispered, "You're such a good child." My mama, she wasn't capable of whispering such sweet words.

(Pg 72-73) I dug my nails into my wrists, and as the sting pushed back my tears, an awful notion struck me: My family, we needed to get the hell out of this roach-infested shack. If we didn't we'd continue to be dumb-assed crackers who drink till dawn in a sorry attempt to forget about all the things they will never have, never become. But there's no forgetting when you're white trash.

(Pg 74-75) Come morning, I slowly floated up through layers of dream-time, feeling a rush of wings against my skin. Mama sat at the kitchen table, her eyes wild and red-rimmed from tears.

GLORY: Come here, Bird, I need to talk to you. . . I don't know how to say this easy, so I'll just say it hard. Your daddy was found this morning by the police. And, well, he had such a tough time with life, he couldn't handle it no more, honey. Bird, your daddy, he's gone to heaven.

BIRD: **(Pg 76)** There wasn't a funeral. We didn't have any money, and the priest wouldn't agree to a service because Daddy wasn't a Catholic and he'd killed himself, so they said, and that was a sin in their church.

(Pg 73) Smirks, stares, stolen glances remind you at every turn that you're not worth squat. So the men, raging drunk, bullshit each other into believing that bruised fists and broken noses will act as charms, paving their way to heaven. And we females – girls and women alike – can't find enough strength in our battered souls to escape. We cast daddies, husbands into near-respectable village idiots in the stories we spin over clotheslines draped with bleach-scented,

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bloodstained damp sheets. And after all that, we still aren't decent. We're still trapped.

(Pg 233-234) My daddy . . . In my mind, I saw his suicide face, him gazing upon the black waters and finding no peace. Tears welled – I squatted and covered my eyes. Goddamn it! A voice filled my head: "Don't you wish you were dead!"

No! No! No! I cried. **(Pg 242)** I screamed. Screamed so loud I must have woke the dead. But nobody came. What do you do when you beg loud and long for help but there ain't nobody listening? **(Pg 234)** I didn't want to be like my daddy.

(Pg 238) Night birds appeared suddenly, flashing past like ghosts. **(Pg 243-244)** A small flock of birds with long, upturned bills, stilt necks, white feathers edged in black. My, oh my, I knew what they were! How odd, I thought, this night I would find my avocets. Creatures with wings could end up most anywhere. **(Pg 26)** And I pray[ed] to Jesus. "Dear sweet Jesus, give me wings so I can fly away from here."

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2003 National Qualifier
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*"**I'll Fly Away**", is a hymn written in 1929 by Albert E. Brumley and published in 1932 by the Hartford Music company*

Lyrics: ***https://www.bluegrasslyrics.com/song/ill-fly-away/***
Music: ***https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Js7QFlKqggk***

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